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002B.2 — Pico: Freedom, Contrast, and Responsibility

Close reading and source discussion · 2026–27

Primary sources: assigned Pico scan, Sources of the Western Tradition, chapter 9, pp. 297–299; Sefer Mitzvot Katan §53 and the comparison sources reproduced below.

MEETING E002.2 — Thursday 10/15 | Freedom, contrast, and responsibility

AIM: How does Pico make freedom carry responsibility?

DISCUSSION — Answer Questions 4–6 aloud and point to the source evidence. You may use the lines for brief notes.

DO NOW — E002.2: Freedom and responsibility

Without notes, answer orally: What makes human beings distinctive, according to Pico? Why does that freedom carry responsibility?

HOMEWORK CHECK: Show yesterday's marked choice verb and consequence.

4. Freedom and agency. In God's speech to Adam, find two verbs or phrases that describe what a human being may choose or become. What do those words make the human being responsible for?

humans have Free will and the ability to make their own choices. This makes the human being responsible for himself and his possessions.

5. Contrast. Pico says a human being may "degenerate" toward lower forms or be "reborn" into higher forms. How does this upward/downward contrast strengthen his argument about freedom? Use one phrase from each side of the contrast.

Pico says that God put man "in the middle of the world."

Leonardo's Vitruvian Man places a measured body within a circle and square. It offers a useful comparison about human proportion and position. The geometry alone does not prove that the circle means "the world" or that Leonardo intended Pico's argument.

Pico says that all things (except human beings) have fixed natures – they are limited in what they are able and supposed to do.

We have already discussed the idea of natural law – things are supposed to behave in a certain way and follow a certain order.

But human beings can change in so many ways – because they don't have a single nature or because they can overcome their nature. Humans can control the way in which they produce things through culture, thereby deciding what the limits of their nature will be; they can make and mold themselves however they choose. This doesn't mean that they can do literally anything they want, but they can do an awful lot to change themselves.

In Pico's words, man is "a creature of indeterminate nature." He envisions God addressing man directly: "We have made thee neither of heaven nor of earth, neither mortal nor immortal, so that with freedom of choice and with honor, as though the maker and molder of thyself, thou mayest fashion thyself in whatever shape thou shalt prefer."

REVISIT LAST WEEK — Human work and nature

MIDRASH TANCHUMA, TAZRIA 5

Read in History on October 8 in 002A.3 Italian Humanism and Classical Revival.

It once happened that the evil Turnus Rufus asked Rabbi Akiva, "Which are the greater works, those of the Holy One Blessed is He or those of flesh and blood?" He said to him, "Those of flesh and blood are greater." Turnus Rufus said, "But the Heavens and Earth - is Man able to make such as those?" Rabbi Akiva said to him, "Don't speak to me about something which is beyond Man, which he has no mastery over, rather speak of things which are found among people." He said, "Why do you circumcise?" He replied, "I knew you were going to ask me about that, which is why I started by telling you that the works of Man are better than the works of the Holy One Blessed is He." Rabbi Akiva brought him stalks [of grain] and loaves [of bread]. He said to him, "These are the works of the Holy One Blessed is He, and these are the works of Man." He said, "Aren't these better than the stalks?!"

https://docs.google.com/document/d/17XS9VcIYLtWxusPAQVrMFrWUOVs4-FbZ/edit

5a. Revisit last week's source. How does Rabbi Akiva use stalks of grain and loaves of bread to answer the question about circumcision? Compare his argument about human work with Pico's description of the human being as the "maker and molder" of oneself. Give one similarity and one difference, using a detail from each source.

They both use similar questions. Pico says what makes humans superior to the rest of creatures, and Akiva says what makes human superior to God. Man takes Gods creation and improves upon it.

Renaissance thinkers thought that man is the master of the contours of his own horizons. And Pico thinks that he can become either worse than animals or like a divine being. There was a longstanding Jewish poetic intuition in the direction of this conclusion. Consider the following sources:

Comparison — Sefer Mitzvot Katan §53

***Sefer Mitzvot Katan* #53 (13th century)**

And the sages said: When the Holy One Blessed Be He created His world, He created the angels on the second day. And He created among them a good inclination without an evil inclination. And afterwards He created animals with an evil inclination but no good inclination. And God (then) said: What satisfaction is there with these creations? If the angels serve Me, this is only because they have no evil inclination. And if the animals do not serve Me, this is because they have no good inclination. I shall create a creature who has both of these inclinations. Therefore, when the evil inclination tells a man to fulfill the desire of his heart, he has a good inclination to say: "You were not created for this, for the animal has already been created." And if the good inclination overpowers the evil inclination, this will be good, for he (man) is more important than the angels. And if, Heaven forbid, the evil inclination is victorious, he (man) will be worse than an animal.

ואמרו חכמים כשברא
הקב"ה את עולמו ברא
המלאכי' ביום ב' וברא בהם
יצר טוב בלא יצר רע ואח"כ
ברא בהמות יצר רע בלא
יצר טוב ואמר הקב"ה מה
קורת רוח יש באלו הבריו'
אם המלאכי' עובדים אותי
זהו לפי שאין להם יצר הרע
ואם אין הבהמות עובדות
אותי זהו לפי שאין להם
יצר טוב אברא בריה ש"ש
לה שני יצרים הללו לפיכך
כשיצר הרע אומר לו לאדם
למלאות תאות לבו יש לו
ליצר טוב לומר לא נבראת
לכך כי הבהמה כבר נבראת
ואם היצר טוב כופה היצר
הרע זהו טוב מפני שהוא
חשוב כן המלאכים ואם
ח"ו יצר טוב נצוח הרי גרוע
כן הבהמה

6. Compare the two sources. What does each source say or imply makes a human being distinctive? State one precise similarity or difference, supported by one detail from Pico and one phrase or detail from the Sefer Mitzvot Katan passage above.

Now, it's important to realize that there's a lot of Greek thought in what Pico is saying.

Aristotle's Nicomachean Ethics connects ethical formation with habituated action (Book II). This offers a comparison with Pico's account of self-formation, while Pico's speech places choice within a distinct religious and philosophical argument.

Platonic traditions associate intellectual cultivation with ascent toward the divine. Pico's account likewise imagines different possibilities for human formation. His seeds-and-cultivation language concerns moral, intellectual, and spiritual development; it is not evidence that nonhuman animals cannot learn or transmit behavior.

QUESTION: Is Pico saying something more?

Yes, he is! Pico is saying that God has given man a mission. It's not simply a matter of what we can do – but there's a very powerful reason to do it, one that goes even beyond ourselves. God made us with the ability to be truly great, and we can accomplish great things and grow close to God in a relationship.

Pico develops this argument as a Christian thinker drawing together several traditions. His religious setting helps explain his argument, but it does not mean that only Christians could value moral responsibility or human formation.

IMPORTANT SIDE NOTE:

Pico's language can invite modern associations. Before importing them, identify what his own passage names: choice, cultivation, reason, intellect, and ascent or degeneration.

In this excerpt, self-formation means cultivating the capacities represented by Pico's seeds and the possibilities of moral and spiritual change. The source does not settle modern scientific or social questions about biology.

Keep the distinction between the historical text and present-day applications: first establish Pico's meaning from his words; then label any extension as a separate argument.

CONCLUSION AND TAKEAWAYS

Pico was an important Renaissance thinker who combined Jewish and Christian covenantal understandings with Greco-Roman philosophy to show the importance of man.

Pico, based on Aristotle, argues that most creatures have a "nature."

Pico argues that man has an "indeterminate nature" and therefore can be the "maker and molder" of himself (to help create himself and strive for excellence).

Man should strive for excellence – that's the purpose that (a covenantal) God put him here for.

This outlook is noteworthy because:

It draws on Greek and Jewish sources, like Aristotle and religious mysticism.

It gives an especially emphatic account of human possibility while continuing older Christian, Jewish, and Platonic concerns. Medieval traditions also valued choice, creativity, and human significance.

It assumes that man is the master of the contours of his own horizons. This key Renaissance assumption would help shape the modern era, one in which man focuses on mastering his surroundings and himself in greater ways than ever before.

SUMMARY — In two sentences, state Pico's argument without using the words "Renaissance" or "humanism." Sentence 1: What makes human beings distinctive? Sentence 2: What responsibility follows from that distinction?

COMPARISON — How do Pico and Rabbi Akiva explain the role of human action in what God has created? Explain one similarity and one precise difference, using Pico's words and Rabbi Akiva's grain-and-bread example. Then explain how the two inclinations in Smak §53 compare with Pico's account of freedom. Be ready to point to the sources when you answer.

DON QUIXOTE — Receive your Edith Grossman edition; locate the Prologue, opening poems, and p. 3. Bring it Thursday, October 22.

DON QUIXOTE — First reading deadlines (Edith Grossman):
Friday, October 23: pp. 11–18, opening commendatory poems (8 pages).
Monday, October 26: Friday pp. 29–38 (10 pages); Sunday pp. 39–49 (11 pages).
Tuesday, October 27: pp. 50–64 (15 pages).
In class: Thursday, October 22, pp. 3–10 (Prologue); Friday, October 23, pp. 19–28 (I.1–2). No Saturday reading.

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HOMEWORK — Friday, October 16

Read 002C1 Petrarch, printed pp. 293–294, stopping before Bruni. Answer the three questions below in 1–2 sentences each, using a detail from the reading. Allow about 15–20 minutes for reading and answers.

1. Why does Petrarch call antiquity his own age's "mother"? What debt does he think his contemporaries refuse to acknowledge?

2. What does comparing the critics to a "black army of ants" coming from a "rotten oak" make the reader feel about them? How fair is that attack?

3. How can Petrarch admire pagan Greek and Roman writers while insisting that he is a Christian? What does this suggest about the purpose of classical learning for him?